

- ▶ **Using a partition as a virtual disk:** Both VMware Workstation and Qemu can be used to treat a real partition as a virtual hard disk. This will improve your PC's performance. But what if you just tried using another partition as a virtual disk where you already had an operating system installed? On Linux, typing in the wrong device filename can cause a disaster. These are mistakes you can't undo; not everything related to virtualization comes with a snapshot button. Don't try anything like this if you're not aware of what partitions are, how they're laid out and how an operating system makes use of them. You're calling for big trouble if you're the adventurous sort and have no idea of where you're going.
- ▶ **Trying cloning:** Many might tell you what we already did – you can actually use the `dd` command in Linux to make an image of your hard disk and later use it as a VM inside Qemu. Be careful, however; as you'll explore, you'll find that `dd` can display reckless behavior. It doesn't care from where it's reading and to where it's writing. If you just make a mistake with pressing the keys “I” and “O” on your keyboard and accidentally type in the “if” argument as “of” and the “of” argument as “if” to the `dd` command, you would have destroyed your hard disk easily and the disaster won't take more than a microsecond after you've pressed enter. Unless you know what you're doing or are ready to be responsible for the havoc and face the consequences, don't go ahead; ask someone who you think might know. Better still, trust Wikipedia and official sources for details.
- ▶ **Deleting your real files inside a VM:** This mistake can be easily committed by even those who're habituated to virtual machines. When you have a shared folder mounted inside the virtual machine, you might forget for a moment that those are real files on your system and try to delete them from within the virtual machine to make more room! This could often happen when the virtual hard disk is filling up. Always take care of how much free space is left inside a virtual machine. If it's getting low, add another virtual hard disk to it.

Despite a few pitfalls, virtualization is the bomb. We hope you're convinced as well as alert enough to try out a virtual machine. We have the software on the DVDs. 